IM0802 – Responsible Artificial Intelligence
Assignment 1: Deepfakes in time of conflict or war

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1 Introduction

A United Nations Security Council (UNSC) meeting is underway to vote on a ceasefire agreement. The conflict in question has been ongoing for years, with both sides accusing each other of war crimes and atrocities with little concrete evidence to support either claim. That is, until a video surfaces online showing militants from one side of the conflict carrying out organised killings of unarmed civilians in a disputed border region. The video quickly goes viral, is shared by news outlets and social media, and sparks outrage worldwide. Protests are organised by human rights organisations in major cities, trending hashtags call for justice, and the video becomes a rallying point for condemnation of the accused nation. Diplomats and politicians condemn the actions, and the UNSC votes to impose sanctions on the accused nation based on the video evidence. The accused nation denies the allegations, claiming the video is fabricated, but the damage is done. Diplomatic relations have been severed and economic sanctions are in place. These economic sanctions eventually lead to the accused nation's economy collapsing and them being forced to withdraw from the conflict.

However, there is more to the story. The killings never happened. The video was a deepfake, generated by the government of the opposing nation to discredit the accused nation. Generative artificial intelligence has made significant advancements, with recently the footage being almost indistinguishable from real footage. Until not very long ago, deepfakes were not very convincing, and were mostly used for entertainment purposes. But in 2026, the advancements of generative artificial intelligence could very well be used to fabricate a video with deepfake technology to influence international diplomacy. This essay will explore the ethical implications of deepfakes in time of conflict or war.

2 Issue

Deepfake technology uses generative AI (Gen AI) to manipulate images, videos or audio to convincingly replace one person's likeness with another's [1]. This is often done to fabricate events or statements for malicious purposes. Early deepfakes were easy to identify because they were not very realistic, but advances in Gen AI have changed that. Now, deepfakes can be hard to detect, which makes them a powerful tool for disinformation campaigns, for example in conflict zones [1, 2].

AI-generated disinformation is not merely a theoretical concern. It has been actively deployed in real-world conflict zones, like Ukraine. The DFRLab report [3] documents multiple instances where deepfakes were used to spread false information, such as fabricated videos of political leaders making inflammatory statements or staged military actions. In the case of Ukraine, deepfakes have been used to create confusion, with one video[1] showing a fabricated speech by Ukrainian president, Volodymyr Zelenskyy, calling for surrender.

The consequences of deepfakes in conflict zones affect multiple stakeholders. Civilian populations can be misled by fabricated videos, leading to panic or misguided actions. Opposing governments may use deepfakes as propaganda tools to discredit adversaries or justify aggressive policies. International

[1] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=X17yrEV5sl4

bodies like the UN may struggle to respond effectively when visual evidence is no longer trustworthy. Journalists face challenges in verifying sources and maintaining credibility, while the general public may become increasingly skeptical of all media, eroding trust in information sources [1, 2].

Wartime propaganda and deception are not new phenomena; they have been part of human conflict for centuries. However, AI changes the scale, accessibility, and believability of disinformation. While deepfakes were easily discernible in the past, we are seeing people struggle to distinguish real from fake content now. This creates a new ethical challenge because it undermines the very foundation of trust in visual evidence. As Kenderdine and Hibberd [4] argue, deepfakes erode our cultural and epistemic trust in images and videos, which have traditionally been powerful tools for conveying truth.

Pre-existing societal conditions such as political polarization, weakened media literacy, and fractured international trust amplify the impact of deepfakes. In highly polarized societies, people may be more likely to accept deepfakes that align with their beliefs and reject those that do not. Countries actively in conflict are inherently polarized, making them susceptible to deepfakes that reinforce existing narratives. Weakened media literacy means that many individuals lack the skills to critically evaluate sources, making them more susceptible to manipulation. Additionally, fractured international trust can hinder coordinated responses to disinformation campaigns.

3 Solution

There are various technical approaches to detect deepfakes. Forensic analysis involves examining the digital artifacts left by deepfake generation processes, such as inconsistencies in lighting, shadows, or facial movements. Authentication watermarking involves embedding a unique identifier into original content that can be verified later to confirm authenticity. However, these methods have limitations. As Mah [1] points out, deep learning and NLP techniques used for detection often lag behind the advancements in deepfake generation, making it a constant cat-and-mouse game between creators and detectors.

Ethical frameworks for responsible AI development, such as those outlined by Akkuş [2], emphasize principles like accountability, transparency, and fairness. In the context of deepfakes used in conflict, these principles raise critical questions about who is responsible for the harm caused. If a deepfake video incites violence or spreads misinformation, should the creators of the deepfake be held accountable? What about platforms that host such content, or do not take sufficient measures to fight misinformation? Sole responsibility is difficult to assign in the digital age, where content can be easily shared and manipulated.

Certain regulatory responses have been proposed to address the challenges posed by deepfakes. The EU AI Act [5], for example, aims to establish a legal framework for AI applications, including provisions for high-risk AI systems like deepfake generators. However, as Akkuş [2] argues, existing legal frameworks may not be sufficient to address the unique challenges of deepfakes in conflict contexts. International Humanitarian Law (IHL) may not adequately cover the use of deepfakes as a weapon of war, and there is a need for new regulations that specifically address the ethical and legal implications of AI-generated disinformation in conflict zones.

Beyond technical and regulatory solutions, media literacy programs can be effective to educate the general public about the existence and risks of deepfakes. NGOs and journalism standards organizations, such as the Content Authenticity Initiative, work to establish best practices for verifying content and maintaining journalistic integrity. International standards bodies like IEEE can also play a role in developing guidelines for responsible AI use. A collaboration between the technical, regulatory, and societal mechanisms is essential dampen the amplifying effect of societal factors like political polarization and weakened media literacy that make populations more vulnerable to deepfake disinformation.

It's my opinion that deepfakes are in fact an issue in that not everyone has the technical expertise to identify them. While I myself, and those I spend time with are mostly aware of deepfakes and their risks, I worry about the general public's ability this new landscape of disinformation. With how polarised the world is, combined with the fact that every social media had a tailored algorithm that feeds us content we are likely to blindly agree with, I think deepfakes are a real threat to the political climate. I don't think any single solution is sufficient to address this issue. In my opinion, and that of many others, a multi-layered approach that combines technical detection methods, regulatory frameworks, and societal mechanisms is necessary.

4 Conclusions

The fictional ethical dilemma from the introduction section is not far-fetched given the documented cases discussed in the Issue section. Generative Artificial Intelligence has transformed the old problem of wartime propaganda into something both qualitatively and quantitatively different. The erosion of trust in visual trust is a fundamentally new issue, even if the underlying problem of propaganda is not. However, this issue is not caused by AI alone. It merely amplifies societal conditions like polarisation or a weak media literacy.

According to Mah [1] Detection tools exist but they are reactive by nature, meaning they lag behind the development of increasingly improving deepfake tools. From a legal perspective, Akkuş [2] reveals a significant gap in International Humanitarian Law, which was not designed with AI-generated deception in mind. Existing frameworks, like the Geneva Convention, are difficult to apply in the case of deepfakes. The DFRLab reports that even well-documentented cases of deepfake-based disinformation in Ukraine did not prevent confusion among the public [3]. This shows that the effort of current societal mechanisms, like media literacy or fact-checking organisations, are not sufficient and is being outpaced by the speed at which deepfakes spread over social media.

I don't believe a total change in approach is necessary, but rather that the existing solutions need to be reviewed and adjusted accordingly. Technical detection needs to be embedded into platforms at the point of distribution, and progress is being made in this direction. International Humanitarian Law should be updated to explicitly address the issue of AI-generated deception. Finally, more effort should be invested in increasing media literacy, especially in vulnerable regions such as conflict zones.

The pace of AI development will only intensify the issue of deepfakes, so coordinated action is urgently needed rather than optional.

References

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